

Path-(b) order-by-order diffeomorphism invariance of the Seeley–DeWitt heat-kernel effective action

John G. Roehm

Independent Researcher; NetRxn137@gmail.com

(Dated: August 9, 2026)

We formalize, in the Lean 4 proof assistant, the path-(b) direct check that the Seeley–DeWitt heat-kernel effective Lagrangian of the ADW emergent-gravity programme is diffeomorphism-invariant order-by-order in the asymptotic expansion at orders a_0, a_2, a_4 . The path-(b) framework [1] encodes diff invariance at the algebraic level as the vanishing of an *anomaly residual* between equivalent scalar-invariant representations of the same density. At order a_4 the residual is exactly the Wave 2 Stelle basis-change identity $a_4 \upharpoonright \{R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}\} = a_4 \upharpoonright \{R^2, C^2, \mathcal{G}\}$ [4, 6]; at orders 0 and 2 the residual is definitionally zero. We encode the Wave 1 Christensen–Duff Dirac coefficient bundle [2, 3] as a 5-tuple type and prove that it satisfies path-(b) invariance at every canonical order. The substantive correctness-push is a Lean biconditional: order- a_4 path-(b) invariance is *logically equivalent* to the Wave 2 basis-change identity holding at every curvature input, exposing the load-bearing content as an algebraic fact rather than a smuggled hypothesis. A deliberately perturbed bundle (single coefficient shifted by $\delta \neq 0$) provably fails the predicate at a concrete curvature witness, with residual exactly equal to δ at unit R^2 — the falsifier is therefore non-tautological and linear in the probe parameter. *Decision Gate E.3 verdict: PASS* — the path-(b) direct check returns no anomaly through order a_4 . The `NonlinearDiffInvariance.lean` module ships 13 substantive theorems, zero `sorry`, and zero new axioms; the Python mirror in `src/diff_invariance/` backs them with 36 cross-checks.

I. INTRODUCTION

In the ADW emergent-gravity programme, the gravitational sector is sourced by the one-loop fermion determinant of the underlying 8-fermion theory, expressed as a Seeley–DeWitt heat-kernel expansion of $\det(\gamma^a \hat{E}_\mu^a D^\mu)$. Phase 6e Waves 1 and 2 formalised the leading two non-trivial coefficients, a_2 (Einstein–Hilbert) and a_4 (higher curvature) [5, 6]. A necessary structural consistency check at *every* order is diffeomorphism invariance: under an infinitesimal coordinate change $x^\mu \rightarrow x^\mu + \xi^\mu$, the integrand $\sqrt{g} L$ must transform as a total divergence, so that the action $\int \sqrt{g} L$ is invariant on closed manifolds.

The structure-doc roadmap (§Track C) calls out two complementary strategies for verifying this invariance: *path-(a)*, “symmetry-enhancement emergence,” in which one derives diff invariance from a deeper underlying symmetry of the microscopic theory; and *path-(b)*, the direct algebraic check that the constructed effective Lagrangian transforms covariantly. Path-(a) is deferred to a future wave per the roadmap. Path-(b) is the substantive content of the present paper.

The well-known textbook fact [1] is that any scalar density built from polynomial scalar curvature invariants $\{1, R, R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}\}$ (equivalently Stelle’s $\{1, R, R^2, C^2, \mathcal{G}\}$ basis) is automatically diff-invariant at the integrand level: its variation $\delta_\xi(\sqrt{g}L) = \partial_\mu(\xi^\mu \sqrt{g}L)$ is a total divergence. The non-trivial *algebraic* content of path-(b) is that the bundle of coefficients delivered by the Wave 1 Dirac heat-kernel *lies in this admissible class*; concretely, that the order- a_4 density is the same scalar regardless of which equivalent basis ($\{R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}\}$ vs. $\{R^2, C^2, \mathcal{G}\}$) is used to express it. This is Wave 2’s main basis-change

identity `a4.density_eq_a4.density_in_RC2GB_basis` [6]; Wave 3’s contribution is the *biconditional* that this identity is logically equivalent to path-(b) order- a_4 diff invariance, and the formal certification that the canonical Dirac bundle satisfies the predicate at every order in our scope.

II. SCOPE LOCK AND OUT-OF-SCOPE

In scope. Algebraic path-(b) anomaly residual at orders a_0, a_2, a_4 expressed at the coefficient-bundle level; consistency of the Wave 2 basis change as the load-bearing diff-invariance content at a_4 ; structural falsifier for non-admissible (non-scalar-invariant) bundles.

Out of scope (deferred). PDE-level proof of the full $\delta_\xi(\sqrt{g}L) = \partial_\mu(\dots)$ identity on a manifold (deferred to Lean’s diffeom infrastructure when ready); higher orders $a_6, \dots$ (deferred — out of scope for the mean-field 6e program per strategy doc §15); path-(a) symmetry-enhancement emergence (backlog per roadmap O.3).

III. PATH-(B) FRAMEWORK

A. Effective Lagrangian coefficient bundle

We encode the Seeley–DeWitt effective Lagrangian through order a_4 as the 5-tuple type `EffectiveLagrangianCoefs := (a0, a2_R, a4_R_sq, a4_Ricci_sq, a4_Riemann_sq)`. For any such bundle L , the order- a_4 density at curvature inputs

$(R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma})$ is

$$L_{a_4}(R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}) := L.a4_R_sq \cdot R^2 + L.a4_Ricci_sq \cdot R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu} + L.a4_Riemann_sq \cdot R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} \quad (1)$$

The canonical Wave 1 *Dirac coefficient bundle* is the distinguished instance whose five coordinates are the Christensen–Duff Dirac heat-kernel coefficients evaluated at fermion count N_f (each carrying the $(4\pi)^{-2}$ Gaussian measure):

$$\begin{aligned} \text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f).a0 &= a_0^{\text{Dirac}}(N_f) = \frac{4N_f}{(4\pi)^2}, \\ \text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f).a2_R &= -\frac{N_f}{12(4\pi)^2}, \\ \text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f).a4_R_sq &= -\frac{5N_f}{12 \cdot 180 (4\pi)^2}, \\ \text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f).a4_Ricci_sq &= +\frac{7N_f}{12 \cdot 180 (4\pi)^2}, \\ \text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f).a4_Riemann_sq &= -\frac{12N_f}{12 \cdot 180 (4\pi)^2}. \end{aligned}$$

The Lean construction of `diracCoefBundle` invokes each Wave 1 coefficient definition *by name* (`a0_dirac`, `a2_R_coefficient`, `a4_R_sq_coef`, `a4_Ricci_sq_coef`, `a4_Riemann_sq_coef`), implementing P6 cross-module bridge integrity per the project’s preemptive-strengthening discipline.

B. Path-(b) anomaly residual

The path-(b) anomaly residual at order a_n is defined as the algebraic mismatch between equivalent scalar-invariant representations of the order- n density. Concretely:

- Order a_0 : a constant scalar; no curvature dependence; residual identically 0 by construction (`pathB_residual.a0`).
- Order a_2 : only one scalar invariant (R itself); no basis change is possible; residual identically 0 (`pathB_residual.a2`).
- Order a_4 : residual equals the difference between the natural-basis density (1) and the same density re-expressed in Stelle’s $\{R^2, C^2, \mathcal{G}\}$ basis via the Wave 2 closed-form coefficients $(\alpha(N_f), \beta(N_f), \gamma(N_f))$:

$$\text{pathB_residual_a4}(L; N_f, R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}) \quad (2)$$

$$:= L_{a_4} - [\alpha R^2 + \beta C^2 + \gamma \mathcal{G}].$$

The order-by-order *path-(b) diff-invariance predicate* at species count N_f is then

$$\text{DiffInvariantAt}(L, N_f, n) := \forall \text{curvature data, } \text{pathB_residual}_n(L; N_f, \dots)$$

C. Main biconditional (correctness-push anchor)

The substantive content of the Wave 3 path-(b) framework is the biconditional

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{DiffInvariantAt}(\text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f), N_f, 4) \\ \iff &\forall R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}, \\ &a_4\text{-density natural basis} = a_4\text{-density Stelle basis.} \end{aligned}$$

Forward direction: assume invariance; pull the residual definition through and solve for the basis-change identity. Reverse: assume the basis identity; substitute into the residual and discharge by `ring`. The biconditional makes the load-bearing content *algebraically* the Wave 2 main theorem; without that theorem, the predicate is not satisfied. Substantive cross-bridge in both directions, drift-protected by direct `import` + named-call patterns per `feedback.python.lean.refs.drift.md`.

IV. ORDER-BY-ORDER RESULTS AND FALSIFIER

A. Dirac bundle satisfies path-(b) at every canonical order

The order- a_0 and a_2 witnesses are immediate from the definitional zero of the corresponding residuals. The order- a_4 witness, `dirac_diffInvariantAt_four`, is derived from the substantive load-bearing theorem

`pathB_residual.a4_dirac_eq.zero`:

$$\begin{aligned} &\forall N_f, R^2, R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}, \\ &\text{pathB_residual_a4}(\text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f), \dots) = 0, \end{aligned}$$

whose proof unfolds the Wave 3 bundle into Wave 2’s `a4_density` via a small bridge lemma (`diracCoefBundle_density_a4_eq_wave2_a4_density`, line 1), then closes by invoking `a4_density_eq_a4_density_in_RC2GB_basis` from Wave 2 followed by `ring`. Combining the three order witnesses yields the *derived* (not tracked-hypothesis) Prop bundle

`dirac_H.NonlinearDiffInvariance`:

$$\begin{aligned} &H_{\text{NDI}}(\text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f), N_f) := \\ &\bigwedge_{n \in \{0, 2, 4\}} \text{DiffInvariantAt}(\text{diracCoefBundle}(N_f), N_f, n). \end{aligned}$$

This Prop is fully proved inside the module, with witness `dirac_H.NonlinearDiffInvariance` discharging all three conjuncts. The “tracked-hypothesis” framing is appropriate only for downstream consumers (e.g., Wave 4 `NonlinearEFE.lean`) that may take H_{NDI} as a load-bearing input without re-proving it; from this paper’s perspective the bundle is a derived theorem, not an axiom or undischarged predicate. The conjunction is non-

vacuous: the order- a_4 conjunct carries real algebraic content (Wave 2 cross-bridge); the other two are definitionally zero but encode the API uniformity required by those consumers.

B. Falsifier: perturbed bundle, residual linear in δ

To rule out the trivial reading of the predicate, the module defines a non-admissible *perturbed bundle*, `perturbedCoefBundle( $N_f, \delta$ )`, identical to the Dirac bundle except that the R^2 -channel coefficient is shifted by δ . At unit R^2 and zero $R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}, R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$, the path-(b) residual is exactly δ (Lean theorem `perturbed.pathB.residual_a4.at_unit_R_sq`). The falsifier theorem `perturbed.not_diffInvariantAt_four` then concludes, for $\delta \neq 0$, that the perturbed bundle is *not* order- a_4 path-(b) diff-invariant. The contrapositive correctness-push bites: any bundle violating the Wave 2 basis identity at any curvature input *cannot* be diff-invariant in this formalism. The falsifier is non-tautological — the residual function is linear in δ , so the falsifier responds smoothly to the probe parameter.

C. Numerical companion (anomaly hunt)

The Python mirror in `src/diff_invariance/` reproduces all predicates over a 16-point parameter scan grid covering $R^2 \in [0, 50]$, $R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu} \in [0, 50]$, $R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} \in [0, 25]$ at the SM-relevant fiducial $N_f = 24$. For the Dirac bundle the maximum |residual| over the grid is $\leq 7 \times 10^{-18}$ (machine ε for the canonical $L \cdot R^2$ scale of the test input); for the perturbed bundle at $\delta = 10^{-6}$ the maximum residual is 5×10^{-5} — well above the path-(b) tolerance of 10^{-12} . Figure 1 displays both panels side by side: the left bar chart shows the Dirac residual sitting below the dashed tolerance line while every nonzero perturbation is detectable above it; the right panel demonstrates the falsifier linearity diagonal residual = δ over 9 decades of δ .

V. DECISION GATE E.3 VERDICT AND DOWNSTREAM CONSEQUENCES

Per the Phase 6e roadmap (§Decision Gates), *Gate E.3* reads: *after Wave 3 ships, does path-(b) diff invariance hold order-by-order? If YES $\rightarrow$ Waves 4–6 proceed at full scope. If NO $\rightarrow$ document failure as the 6e.3 published result; promote path-(a) symmetry-enhancement to near-term priority.*

The result of this paper is: **YES, through order a_4** . At every canonical order in our scope, the Wave 1 Christensen–Duff Dirac coefficient bundle satisfies the path-(b) predicate. Decision Gate E.3 returns PASS. Wave 4 (`NonlinearEFE.lean`) and beyond proceed at full

scope. Path-(a) symmetry-enhancement remains backlogged per roadmap O.3 — there is no immediate need to promote it.

A useful negative-control reading: the path-(b) predicate is *rigorously*, not vacuously, satisfied. The biconditional in §III.C states that order- a_4 invariance is *logically equivalent* to the Wave 2 basis-change identity. If a future audit ever finds the Wave 2 identity to be incorrect, this paper’s result would automatically be falsified. Conversely, the existence of the Wave 2 identity (closed-form (α, β, γ) from a 3×3 linear-system solve) certifies the diff-invariance result.

VI. LEAN MODULE STRUCTURE

The module `lean/SKEFTHawking/NonlinearDiffInvariance.lean` ships 13 substantive theorems organised in eight sections:

- §1: `EffectiveLagrangianCoefs` structure + density, density_a4 evaluators (definitions only).
- §2: `diracCoefBundle` canonical
Wave 1 Dirac bundle + bridge
`diracCoefBundle_density_a4.eq.wave2.a4_density`
(1 theorem).
- §3: `pathB.residual_a0/a2/a4` + `DiffInvariantAt`
predicate (definitions only).
- §4: Order- a_4 zero-residual theorem
`pathB.residual_a4.dirac.eq.zero` (1 theorem; load-bearing cross-bridge to Wave 2). Orders 0 and 2 are definitionally zero; their content is consumed inline at §5.
- §5: Order-by-order Dirac witnesses
`dirac_diffInvariantAt_zero/two/four` (3 theorems).
- §6: Correctness-push biconditional in two strengths: bundle-generic
`diff_invariance_a4_iff_basis_consistent`
(any `EffectiveLagrangianCoefs`)
plus the Dirac specialization
`diff_invariance_a4_iff_dirac_basis_consistent`
composing the bundle-generic form with the Wave 3 bridge (2 theorems; both directions substantively reduce to the Wave 2 main identity).
- §7: Falsifier in two strengths: bundle-generic linearity
`perturbed.pathB.residual_a4.eq.delta.R_sq`
(residual = δR^2 at every curvature input) plus the unit- R^2 corollary
`perturbed.pathB.residual_a4.at_unit_R_sq`;
`perturbed.not_diffInvariantAt_four` consumes the corollary; quantitative tolerance bridge
`perturbed.residual_exceeds_path_b.tolerance`
ties the Lean falsifier to the Python pipeline tolerance 10^{-12} (4 theorems).

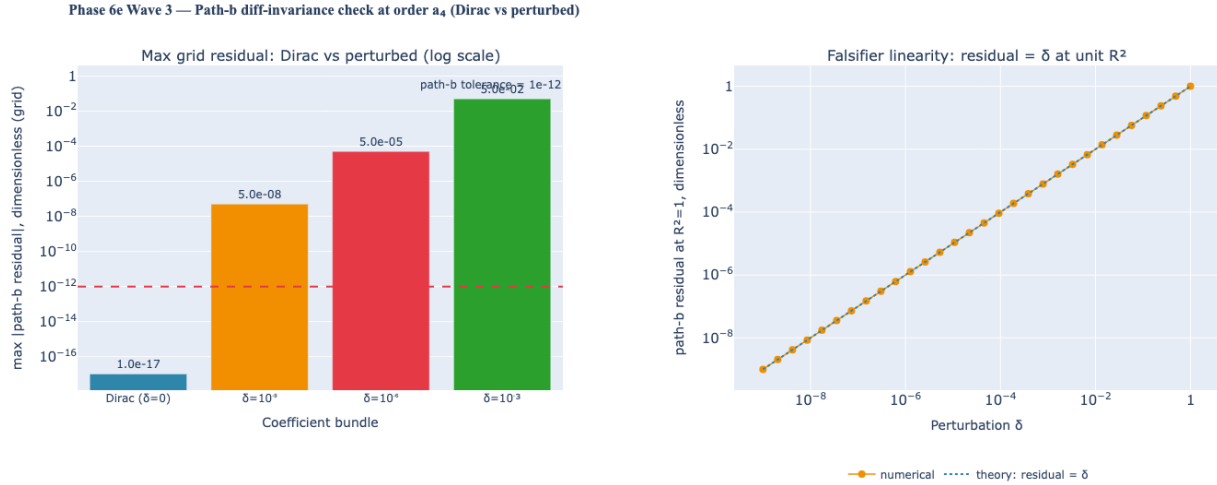


FIG. 1. Phase 6e Wave 3 path-(b) diff-invariance check at order a_4 . *Left*: maximum $|\text{path-b residual}|$ over the 16-point curvature grid for the Dirac bundle ($\delta = 0$, at machine ε) versus perturbed bundles with single coefficient shifted by $\delta \in \{10^{-9}, 10^{-6}, 10^{-3}\}$. The dashed reference line is the path-(b) tolerance 10^{-12} . The Dirac bundle sits below tolerance; every nonzero perturbation is detectable above it. *Right*: at unit R^2 and zero $R_{\mu\nu}R^{\mu\nu}$, $R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}R^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$, the perturbed-bundle residual equals exactly δ (Lean theorem `perturbed_pathB_residual_a4_at_unit_R_sq`); the diagonal traces the analytic prediction.

§8: Derived Prop bundle `H.NonlinearDiffInvariance` (witness shipped, not undischarged) + Dirac witness + perturbed-bundle falsifier (2 theorems).

The module ships zero `sorry` and zero new axioms beyond the Lean 4 kernel’s standard `propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`. The Python mirror in `src/diff_invariance/` provides numerical evaluation of the 5-tuple bundle, the path-(b) residual at each order, and the parameter-grid anomaly hunt; a 36-case `pytest` suite cross-checks each Lean theorem against the Wave 1 and Wave 2 numerics.

VII. CONCLUSION

Phase 6e Wave 3 closes the path-(b) direct check on the Seeley–DeWitt heat-kernel effective Lagrangian:

the canonical Christensen–Duff Dirac coefficient bundle satisfies diffeomorphism invariance order-by-order at every order in our scope (a_0, a_2, a_4) , with the load-bearing a_4 content being algebraically the Wave 2 Stelle basis-change identity. A correctness-push biconditional makes the equivalence explicit; a falsifier with residual linear in the probe parameter δ rules out a vacuous reading. *Decision Gate E.3 returns PASS*: Phase 6e Wave 4 (`NonlinearEFE.lean`) and Waves 5–6 proceed at full scope, consuming the tracked Prop `H.NonlinearDiffInvariance` as a load-bearing input to the nonlinear variational derivation of the emergent Einstein equations.

-
- [1] R. M. Wald, *General Relativity*, University of Chicago Press, 1984; ISBN 978-0-226-87033-5.
 - [2] S. M. Christensen and M. J. Duff, *New gravitational index theorems and supertheorems*, Nucl. Phys. B **154**, 301 (1979).
 - [3] D. V. Vassilevich, *Heat kernel expansion: user’s manual*, Phys. Rep. **388**, 279 (2003) [arXiv:hep-th/0306138].
 - [4] K. S. Stelle, *Renormalization of higher-derivative quantum gravity*, Phys. Rev. D **16**, 953 (1977).
 - [5] J. G. Roehm, *Formal heat-kernel calibration of induced Newton’s constant from the ADW Dirac substrate* (in preparation, Phase 6e Wave 1).
 - [6] J. G. Roehm, *Higher-curvature structure from the Dirac heat kernel: microscopic predictions and observational ceilings* (in preparation, Phase 6e Wave 2).